the pup in hound's flesh

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the pup in hound's flesh

by KittensMittens

Summary

"*Get out!*" Phainon snarls.

-Mydei shuts the door.

The first thing that comes to mind is utter rage. How *dare* an alpha invade his space and ask him to *get out* on top of it? It just takes about every ounce of Mydei's rational thought to not storm in there and throw the shithead out.

No – he needed to make sense of this all, first.

Phainon was indeed in rut. And Phainon was indeed in his room.

Mydei just did not understand why he had sought out another *alpha's* room of all places for refuge.

Phainon never grew up as a normal alpha. Or had a healthy rut. Or felt all the protective, affectionate, possessive instincts towards omegas to their full extent as he should.

Then Mydei enters his life. The final nail in the coffin establishing his abnormality.

And now Mydei has to deal with a cranky alpha in rut invading his bedroom.

Notes

just a short note about what scents i imagine these two to have-

Phainon – grassy wind (?), old ink, smelling him feels like burying ones nose in sun-soaked fabric.

Mydei – iron-rusty like blood, a hint of pomegranate and firewood, maybe a bit of baked bread

based on my thread fic with Phainon's POV added!

They don't have full-blown sex in this fic, but they do indirectly agree to it for future ruts and letting the other knot them when the day comes.

See the end of the work for more notes

After a few seconds of taking in the scene in his bedroom, Mydei very carefully steps out, slowly shutting the door behind him.

Staring numbly at the chipped pattern on the wall in front doesn't remove the image of Phainon slumped on his bed, heady and feverish from a rut, from his mind.

No, perhaps Mydei had been *hallucinating*. Hallucinations did not simply come upon him on a whim, but it wasn't a new-

A deep breath has him smell the sharp scent coming out in jagged waves through the gap beneath his door – of freshly trimmed grasses and printed and ink and a hint of sun.

Undeniably an alpha in rut – specifically Phainon, with his scent amplified by the intensity of his affliction.

Mydei shuts his eyes.

Massages his nose.

Cutting off the visual input only makes him more aware of the pained, smothered groans coming from inside, the aggressive waves of pheromones – of *Phainon* inside his room.

Deep breaths do not help.

Mydei opens the door again – just by a crack. The sight of the Heir on his bed assaults him again – pale hair sticking to his forehead with sweat, his coat hanging off the edge of the bed, his shirt torn wide and open, exposing his sculpted-

Phainon hears it this time, his hazy eyes flicking up to meet Mydei's through the crack in the door – the blue of his irises nearly swallowed by black.

He barely registers the heat in them when-

"*Get out!*" Phainon snarls.

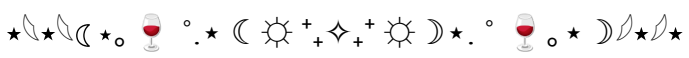
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Aglaea spends a generous amount of time staring back at Mydei, presumably waiting for him to explain his presence.

"I know you have already seen it."

The goldweaver blinks and then she gazes off into the distance, reading through thousands of strands of threads to see what Mydei was talking about.

And then the slightest hint of confusion mars her features.

"This is…"

"Explain." Mydei waves in the direction of his dwellings. He did not intend to sound so blunt with her but a Phainon in rut was not in his list of situations he had to deal with.

After a minute of contemplation, Aglaea sighs.

"Before I answer, Mydeimos, would you like to try and come up with an answer yourself?"

Mydei feels his eyebrow twitch.

“I do not know the Deliverer for as long as you do, Aglaea.”

“I’m aware. It simply is easier to give an answer to one who has explored their own answers first.”

Mydei looks up at the building, at his window which was currently shut, hiding the Deliverer from the rest of the world.

“He doesn’t happen to be an omega pretending to be an alpha, is he?”

It sounded utterly ridiculous but it also was the most plausible explanation for him to be in Mydei’s room.

“Did he smell like one, Mydei?”

“…”

Grasses flying along with crisp winds, fabrics soaked in the sun – the scent aggressive and seeking nothing but ownership-

No. Absolutely not. Phainon wasn’t even showing any nesting behaviour on top of it.

“ Get out!!

And…that.

The other possibility was worse to imagine, as unrealistic as it was.

“Does he…has he mistaken *me* for an omega then?”

Aglaea only answers him with a withering look.

No. Mydei’s presence as an alpha was too imposing, to say the least – to the extent that even other alphas would offer their silent deference. Ever since he had set foot in the city, only Phainon had been unaffected by it.

“Phainon is a unique case, to put it mildly.” Aglaea finally relents, “He has had quite a troubled experience with his reality as an alpha.”

“…Something to do with his village?” he offers. It wasn’t unheard of for traumas to condition deeply harmful tendencies into an alpha, completely disrupt their rut cycles and pheromone management. Especially with losses so devastating suffered at an age so young.

Mydei could have ended up like him too, had it not been for the older alphas in the detachment present to guide him.

“I do not know what transpired in the time between the destruction of Aedes Elysiae and his joining the Chrysos Heirs.” Aglaea seats herself on a delicate throne of golden threads spun out of thin air, “I have just gleaned enough to understand Phainon presented as an alpha when he had no one to guide him – he worked through those emotions and instincts with the horrors of his bereavement still fresh in his mind. With the way he presents himself to the rest of us – no one would ever be able to tell. He does have frightening amounts of control over himself.”

“Except his ruts.”

“The time when alphas have the least amount of control over themselves.” Mydei’s gaze follows a lone string of gold that she twirls around her finger, “That is when the façade of the perfect ‘Deliverer’ begins to crumble.”

“What ‘perfect’ are you talking about – that fool can’t even climb on a dromas without getting kicked away first.”

Aglaea gives him an impassive blink.

“Well, whatever it is, his ruts are consequently more erratic. No pattern, no warning and the abnormal aggression and volatility…makes him a danger for the others.”

"…"

It makes Mydei think about the Phainon in his room, and overlooking how he had howled at him to get out…he did not seem anything like it in his eyes.

Phainon looked docile, if anything.

"Phainon has strived to conceal this from the rest…he would completely disappear for a week and at least one of us needs to know why and that is the only reason he shared it with me."

"Does he not seek the company of omegas? I…am sure there would be plenty who would readily give themselves…" Mydei trails off. Phainon was a powerful warrior, held himself relatively well in public and was undeniably blessed with a great physique and beautiful features.

Any omega or even a beta would want him.

So why was the mere thought of such a logical reasoning filling Mydei's mouth with a sour taste?

"He stays away from them – he fears his lack of restraint too much to be around them."

So that HKS just opted to suffer through it *alone*?

"Wouldn't an alpha like me make it *worse*?" Mydei points a finger at himself, "And yet that fool is rolling around in my sheets that obviously smell like me."

"That is the most intriguing thing about it, actually." Aglaea tilts her head and Mydei feels the very mild hint of interest in her expression, "He gets even worse around alphas when he's close to a rut; even picking up the slightest scent of one sets him off. Despite being a beta, sometimes I would make him snap because I lingered too long around Cipher. He has never fared well around them until…you."

"That makes no sense." Mydei deadpans.

"*Your* behaviour does not follow established logic either, Mydeimos."

Mydei blinks.

"What."

"For an alpha of your quality, you are not affected by the presence of another taking over your den."

"I *am* affected – that's why I came to you-"

"I shall rephrase." Aglaea leans forward, a glint in her lime eyes, "You are affected within *reason*. You are not agitated by instinct – you are here out of *worry* for Phainon, not because you want to rip him into two from an alpha's wounded pride."

Her words leave him frozen mid-thought.

"Did you not even notice it?" Aglaea continues, neutrally merciless, "His scent – the scent of an alpha who has been rivalling you ever since you met, your only match, your only equal – a threat to your dominance. This scent is *all over* your territory, you smelt it first hand and the only thing that bothered you was your conscious understanding of decorum – the fact that it *logically* should not be that way. Any other alpha in your place would have attempted to bite Phainon's throat out without question."

Mydei manages – just barely – to not have his mouth hang open like a fool.

Aglaea leans back, a smugly satisfied look briefly flashing across her face. She was thoroughly enjoying this.

Old inks printed into yellow parchments. Crisp sunshine clinging to dried clothes. The scent of dew kissing lush grasses. This was what Phainon always smelled like, a scent that Mydei had always found pleasant – *calming* even, with time.

This was an alpha they were talking about here. This was something that *shouldn't have happened*.

How many times had Phainon been near him? How many times had they exchanged blows, soaked in heat and adrenaline and pheromones? Not once had it evoked that natural aggressive posturing in Mydei that one would expect from a fellow alpha, made his innards coil at a scent he should have found unbearably pungent, made him bare his teeth like an unrestrained animal.

If Mydei bristled, it was due to the easy confidence with which Phainon taunted him. If he growled, it was to reply to his challenging jeers, inviting him to yet another nonsensical contest. If he battled him, his blood boiling with the urge to dominate, it was only to wipe that annoying smirk off that imbecile's face.

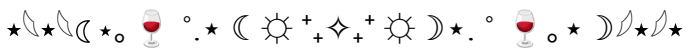
Because it was *Phainon*. Phainon who would recklessly slap his back in public, Phainon who would walk around with that sunlit smile on his stupid face, Phainon who would strut around their impromptu arenas with the arrogance of a warrior who could never be bested, Phainon whose scent would make Mydei want to bury his face into the crook of his neck and inhale more.

How had Mydei not realized it before? Had it all been drowned out by the static of their unceasing rivalry?

"It is mere conjecture-" Aglaea prepares to gently hammer the last nail, "-but if Phainon's scent sparks no fight within you, it is possible that he feels something similar towards yours."

"He asked me to get out."

"And yet it is your scent that he seeks solace in, Mydeimos. You are his equal, so he does not fear being subjugated by you. What might help is that you establish the same. That you are not someone he can hurt."



Even when Mydei finds himself standing before his own door, Aglaea's parting words still felt like they abandoned him at an impasse.

How even was a rutting alpha to be handled? He didn't know and he was absolutely sure Phainon didn't know shit either.

Gripping the knob with his hand, Mydei allows himself a few seconds. It was obvious his rut had intensified; the scent louder and far more volatile.

He had sent off his soldiers soon after learning about the intruder, but how had Phainon even broken in without a fight breaking out?

Well, all that could be damned; all Mydei knew was that he had to wing it once he stepped in – answers could come later.

The second the door creaks open, Mydei sees Phainon jump, wildly sitting up.

A mess. An utter *mess* that man was – white hair tousled and sticky with sweat, blue eyes wide and wanting, a deep flush colouring his cheeks and bleeding into his shoulders. Tension burnt into every inch of his frame, a thin sheen of sweat covering his skin, his breaths uneven and restless.

A sight utterly *revolting* for another alpha to behold.

Mydei only feels heat pool into his stomach.

As he closes the door behind him, Phainon tenses like a coiled spring, jaw clenched and eyes glazed and guttural.

"The fuck are you looking at me like that for?" Mydei goads and something flashes in Phainon's eyes.

He moves – too fast and Mydei only heard a crazed snarl before he feels him crash into him, both landing on the floor.

Phainon was easier to fight without a sword in his hand.

“Deliverer – get a hold of yourself-” Phainon’s fist connects with his cheek before he grabs Mydei’s hair and slams his head against the floor.

But the bastard being in rut made him a whole new handful to deal with. It was only Mydei's absurd physiology that has the blow reel him away from his senses for less than a second before he comes to.

Not without the newfound urge to rip Phainon’s throat out with his teeth, as Aglaea had told him he typically should want to do.

Mydei wrestles him around a bit before managing to pin him down on the floor, struggling to maintain the position with how Phainon kept thrashing beneath him, clawing at his arms and attempting to bite him, even.

The scent of his rut surrounds them, sharp and angry and uncontrollable and for the first time, Mydei feels relieved that his scent did not set off his own aggression as one would expect. This would have been a *bloodbath*. This shithead was so, so goddamn lucky it was *Mydei* handling him.

Phainon says something, voice too garbled for him to interpret. Mydei tries to pin his hands down and immediately Phainon attempts to drive his knee into his side.

Maybe he should still sock him in the face *once* for good measure.

“G…et….way! Get away!” he finally hears and Mydei glares down at his face. Phainon’s chest heaves wildly, his eyes almost feral until Mydei catches the tinge of panic in them.

And he sets his foot down.

“No.”

"*Mydei*!!"

"These are *my* dwellings. How dare you hole yourself up in here and then order *me* to leave?"

Phainon looks almost pained at that and attempts to throw him off again.

"And I know there is comfort you seek with my scent – *that's* why you're here."

"You shouldn't be around me – I can't control myself-!"

Something – likely insanity – compels Mydei to lean closer to the struggling Phainon, tilting his head to bare his neck to him, a mere inch away from his nose.

Phainon feels so, so tense in his arms. And Mydei waits, not loosening his grip on him even for a second, even when Phainon goes utterly still beneath him, even when his pulse hammers violently beneath his grip on his wrists.

"Shut up for *once*, Deliverer and listen." He orders, keeping his neck bared. It was a risky, *risky* game that Mydei was playing – leaving himself open yet refusing to completely *submit*.

And he waits.

Minutes tick.

And then, almost as if fearful, Phainon's nose presses against Mydei's throat, against his scent gland so temptingly offered.

And he waits.

Waits until Phainon's breathing gradually grows stable, his pulse steadily easing into a rhythm with the tension slowly dissipating from his limbs. He hears him inhale his scent in, and exhale out a low, barely concealed whine.

“I am not here to hurt you, Deliverer.” Mydei speaks, softly. What he gave was not submission but it was sufficient, “Nor can you do anything to me.”

“You…you don’t know what I could do – what I have thought of-”

“And what *have* you done to me?” Mydei turns his head, staring down at Phainon, the fight dulled from his gaze and his voice, “With what *resolve* could you do anything – I managed to pin you down and immobilize you, I bared my neck to you, made it easy for you to bite my throat out and what did you do?”

Phainon’s eyes widen, “I – you shouldn’t have to deal with this-”

“I’m *fine*, Phainon.” Mydei straightens up, eliciting a choked noise from him, “I’m here by my own will – no one, not even you, gets to browbeat me into doing *anything*.”

“You…Mydei, you shouldn’t-”

“You need to help me help you, Deliverer-”

“Mydei, you shouldn’t *sit on me like this*.” Phainon gushes, his voice almost trembling – so unlike its usual clear, stable tone. Mydei frowns.

“What-?”

“You…” Phainon’s eyelids flutter as he strives to look elsewhere, “You’re sitting on-”

“…”

Mydei looks down, taking in their current position, with him straddling Phainon’s-

And he shuts his eyes, exhaling sharply through his nose before promptly standing up.

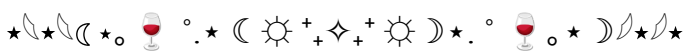
Phainon remains sprawled on the floor while Mydei gets off him, slightly twisting his body to the side and throwing his arm over his face. Mydei watches him like that for a while – Phainon’s shirt had torn even more during their scuffle, exposing more of his chest. Shaky breaths were spilling out of his parted lips and he slightly curls his legs at feeling the prince’s gaze on him and Mydei’s hands tighten into fists at his sides.

Phainon’s scent hangs thick in the air – it no longer radiated off him in haphazard waves but it still clung to him like a second skin and Mydei’s feels his own pheromones respond to it, his control slipping to let a whisper of faint rust and pomegranate bleed from his flesh.

Phainon pulls back his arm, eyes darting up towards Mydei before raking all over him.

Mydei holds back a swear under his breath. It wasn't enough that this fool was barely more than a hound at the moment – he also had to look utterly *ravishing* as well. Mydei would have probably taken him right then and there had he not remembered that it was Phainon currently in a rut.

Glaring down at him for a while, Mydei almost holds his hand out to help him before deciding against that and just scooping Phainon up in his arms, who lets out an indignant whine as he is tossed carelessly onto the bed.



Mydei lays beside Phainon, rigid and unmoving – not touching, not speaking. Each minute that drags its feet only turns the air clammier; thick with the strain of what was to unfold, or never would.

At least Phainon's breath sounded stabler than before, even if the man managed to stare at him simultaneously like an animal cornered and a prey left starving.

"Deliverer."

"Mmn?"

"…What would you like to do?"

Phainon blinks, slow and weak.

"I…what am I supposed to-"

"Do you want me to leave?"

“No!” Phainon nearly shouts, throwing his hand out to splay it over Mydei’s chest. Warm and clammy with sweat and desperation.

Well, at least he made physical contact.

Mydei shakes his head and pulls him closer. Phainon tenses again and he waits, patiently, as he gradually eases himself into his arms, gingerly tucking his face into his neck.

“Alphas in rut need an omega companion to help them through it.”

“…I know.”

“But you want nothing to do with them. It is only my presence that you tolerate.”

“Mhmn.”

“…And I’m not an omega.”

He hears a pointed sniff against his scent gland, “I can *tell*, Mydeimos.”

This was going to be a long day. Mydei huffs and stares up at the ceiling. He obviously *knew* what an alpha needed, he just didn’t know how to personally *fulfill* said need.

He feels a kiss against his throat and shuts his eyes; the low thrum of desire that wells up within him was undeniable. Absently, his hand delves into Phainon’s hair – it felt limp and sweaty and strange to touch – so different from how soft and fluffy it usually looked.

“Mydei…”

His hands begin to paw around his torso.

“I’m sorry – I don’t know why; this wasn’t how – shit, you must be *hating* this-”

“Deliverer, I’m fine with it.”

Phainon freezes in his arms and Mydei tightens them around him by instinct. Doubt rarely crept up on him but Mydei wasn’t sure if this was the right thing to do, how much of it was his own desire taking over the reins. He didn’t want Phainon to be alone in the wreck of it all but he didn’t want to be *wrong* either.

But Mydei pushes on, nonetheless.

“Take me as your mate for this.”

It feels like a snap – the way the scent enveloping them turns sharper in a split second before oddly dropping and then rising again.

“No.” Phainon rasps, “Mating – no, I can’t…just no. That is the *one* thing I won’t do.”

“Why?” Mydei asks after a pause, gently. He couldn’t afford to agitate him further, “It should give you some relief, at the very least.”

“No, I don’t think that would work, Mydei-”

“I know it’s different – it won’t be what it’s like with an omega-”

“That’s not *it*, Mydei.” Phainon squeezes his eyes shut, “These ruts…they have always been a *fight*. I slip away and become something I can’t control, I can’t recognize – that I *fear*. I haven’t had a single one that I didn’t practically *claw* myself out of. Just minutes ago, I attacked you. What if I do that again – what if I hurt you?”

“But you’re fine, right now. You’re doing well, are you not, Deliverer?”

“I am. It…isn’t supposed to be like this.” His eyes flutter open and his hands travel over his chest again, almost as if in awe, “Perhaps it’s because you are here, but I still don’t know – you’re just offering yourself and – I don’t know how to handle that.”

Phainon slings his leg over Mydei’s waist, wrapping himself tighter around him.

“And…it’s not about you being an alpha or substituting for an omega – before everything else, you are *Mydei* to me. That’s how I *wanted* it to be, that’s how it *was* and this fucking rut just *takes* that away.”

Mydei’s fingers find Phainon’s jaw before slowly trialing upward, brushing over his eyelids as he closes his eyes before pushing away the damp bangs from his forehead to press a kiss against it.

“I’ll still be your Mydei, Deliverer – nothing that you do to me will take that away.”

Phainon looks up at him – a frown still lingered on his features, but he doesn’t argue, doesn’t pull away and Mydei understands that to an extent, he at least believed him.

"…Next time." Phainon finally speaks after a long beat, "I believe you – I don't believe I can stop being entirely afraid just yet. It…won't go away that easily."

"…"

"Would you still stay with me?"

"Do you see me running anywhere?"

A pause and then a tired smile appears on Phainon's face, which instantly gets replaced by surprise when Mydei moves to grab his jaw, forcing him to stay in place.

"But don't you get ahead of yourself, you HKS-" he lets affection bleed into his goading and Phainon's eyes endearingly widen, "I'm not submitting to you in any manner – you have some *nerve*, having me booked for your next rut as well."

"…"

"I shall have you return the favour two-fold when I have my rut next. And don't you think I'd be anything like you; just be satisfied with *cuddling* like this."

Phainon blinks slowly. Looks elsewhere for a bit, as if he was only just registering the consequences being promised to him. And then looks back at him.

"Ok."

"…"

Well, Mydei hadn't been expecting that.

"You agreed quite fast." Considering his current state, Mydei had expected him to at least bare his teeth at him – most alphas did not take kindly to having other alphas fuck them.

"Well, something's telling me *you* want this more than me."

"Fuck you." Mydei shoves at him, but Phainon only clings closer; the grin that forms on his face lifts a weight off his chest, "*You* were the one who went and stink-bombed my entire

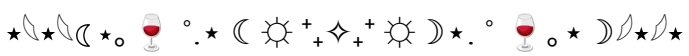
room, you little shit – I had to make an exception because *you* made yourself my headache."

"I don't stink."

"You do."

"You *like* how I smell." Phainon leans in, gaze drilling into him, "I see how you stare at my neck after our spars, when I get too close."

Mydei mumbles out a few curses in his mother tongue, but his aggression simply could not hold out anymore.



"How is it?"

Mydei stares at the pile of pillows and blankets Phainon had arranged in an oval shape on the bed. With time wearing on, he had eventually started giving in to and exploring some of his softer instincts as an alpha, one of which was preparing a good nest for his mate. And he had spent a considerable amount of time rubbing his wrists against the cushions before covering it all up with his coat and shirt.

Once Phainon was done, he had turned towards Mydei for his opinion.

Mydei looks up from the 'nest' meeting his wide, expectant eyes.

"A bit shit, really. Any omega would see this and walk out on you."

Phainon glares at him.

“You – I worked hard on this you know?”

“You did?” Mydei hums, biting back a grin at seeing his indignance, “Fine. It is amazing, Lord Phainon. I would turn to no other place to spend my heats in.”

“You are a gigantic prick.” Phainon pushes at him and Mydei grabs him and pulls him into a kiss.

Which was probably not the wisest thing to do to a currently ‘*very horny but doesn’t want to fuck*’ alpha but Mydei’s room and bedding was going to smell like this scoundrel for *weeks* so he could make him suffer some payback for it.

Mydei moves to settle into the ‘nest’ when he feels strong arms wrap around him and lift him up. He almost snarls but stops himself, staying quiet as Phainon gently lays him on the nest and tucks his clothes around him. As an alpha, instinct made Mydei bristle at being handled like this, but the sight of Phainon looking so pleased by himself douses it.

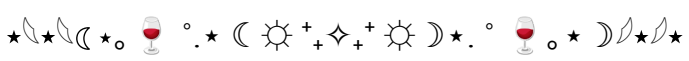
“How do you feel?” he asks.

“So safe and secure and protected. Thank you, my alpha.” Mydei deadpans.

“Do you ever consider being nicer?”

“I *am* being nice; that’s why I’m letting you get away with all this.” Mydei shifts, letting Phainon drape himself over him like a protective cover.

In retrospect, perhaps Mydei didn’t quite mind being dragged into this mess.



What was a rut really supposed to be?

Phainon never had anyone to really tell him about it.

His throat burns.

He had no companion during his travels around Amphoreus. He belonged nowhere, and everything that belonged to him had long been reduced to a pile of soulless, grey ash, in the jaws of flames he had been too weak to douse.

He had only just eviscerated the swathe of titankin that he had been ambushed by.

When Phainon had presented as an alpha, he had only just barely made it out of a bloody battle.

Just made it out. Barely. The lacerations on his body stung like fire, the bruises littered all over ached like he was about to break in pieces any second.

The bloodlust and adrenaline still coursing through his veins while his throat burned like it was set on fire.

His throat burns. Phainon almost believes one of the beasts was still alive, had plunged its blade into his neck and dragging it down its length to tear him open.

He feels up his neck.

Nothing.

But he knew there was something – there was something slowly creeping inside him, branding itself deep into his flesh, setting his veins with a fire he could not understand.

His nails dig into his skin. Tear into it. The fire doesn't stop. There is ash sticking to the walls of his lungs, spilling into his chest, into everything-

Phainon has no lucid memory of that rut – just that he came to his senses with golden and scarlet blood staining his fingers and his clothes. His neck bled – narrowly healed by a local medic in the small village he had stumbled into.

Phainon runs out of the village within hours of waking up.

Perhaps ruts meant to completely give oneself up to instinct. To their deepest desires.

In that time, Phainon only understood one thing about himself – he craved destruction, he longed to sink his blade into the flesh of the creatures that had ripped his home away from him, to do so again and again and again until he couldn't even remember what shapes their bodies took on before he charged at them.

He longed for his own nails tearing his own skin open, to see if he bled red or golden.

How many times has it happened? How many times has he woken up, his body still feeling like it had been completely burnt from the inside, his knuckles still raw and bloodied, blood smeared on the cracked wall in front of him, the wall of whatever room he managed to shut himself in?

It was easier, to use them for violence. To start hunting for enemy encampments whenever he felt his rut drawing close. There was no fixed pattern to it, Phainon understood after the first few months. It would swoop in on him, it would take, it would leave him behind as a broken shell who couldn't bear to look at himself in the mirror without screaming in terror, without attacking his own image.

Only the dryness that would start coating his tongue, would make him crave to quench it with repulsive blood, would tell him what he needed to know. To grab his blade, stay far, far away from civilization, and butcher the enemies that the black tide regurgitated on the world.

Sometimes Phainon would look into the broken mirror in the throes of his rut and swallow the bile rising in his throat – his figure cloaked in black and face covered with an ebony mask – the image fluctuating between his own, gaunt face and the monster that he so feared. And then follows the sting of tearing flesh – the only thing that drove that creature away, left his nails with dried blood in the morning.

And yet deep down, Phainon craved – craved some inexplicable warmth; he feels a low tug in his gut that wasn't anything like the bloodlust he knew, the aggression, the unending thirst

for dominance, for conquest.

He has caught hints of it in some of the villages he passed through in his travels. A scent carried by the winds, soft and sweet, of baked pies and sweet milk and dewy flowers. A sight of gentle figures – of safety and home, of soft smiles and warm eyes and glowing skin. Accompanied by their partners – people who were strangely similar to Phainon, but not in a manner that made *sense*, that made him think they were his kin.

It doesn't stir anything significant inside of Phainon – there was always a dull realization that he *should*, that *this* was what he should seek, but it never pulled him in. Not the way cleaving through bodies with his sword did. Maybe that's why he never truly felt that kinship with their partners either; there was something distorted in him that robbed him of the instincts that guided *them*; there was something *whole* in them that Phainon *missed*.

Phainon had tried.

He eventually approached one of the 'gentle' ones in another village. He didn't know what to say, what exactly he was supposed to be for that villager, what he was supposed to want. He just knew there was something he was supposed to seek, but his brain was blank, his instincts gave him nothing and the villager's eyes only widened with fear when he approached them with the stack of hay they had dropped on the ground.

It was only a slight slip but the look seared itself into Phainon's brain. The villager smiled and took the hay from him, but couldn't hide the tremor in their voice when they gave him their thanks.

Was it him? Had Phainon forgotten what it was like to be human, to be around other humans? Was it because the scent of iron and ash hung heavy around him? Was it because he couldn't conceal it no matter how much he scrubbed himself raw and bleeding in the ponds and streams – because he didn't know what else to do? Cyrene had always spoken of him being a gentle, silly child, waving his tiny toy sword around with no technique, incapable of hurting even a bug.

What had happened to that child?

*Phainon left the village that very night, completely sure that whatever latent desires had clung to him wasn't **meant** for him – couldn't ever be anything more for him. Not when he was this twisted, broken thing, too different at the core, too dangerous.*

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It is when he settles in Okhema, taking up the mantle and duties of a Chrysos Heir, that Phainon finally learned about ‘secondary genders’ and that he was an ‘alpha’. That there were others – betas and omegas, each having their own roles and needs and instincts. That there was a whole system of social dynamics and expectations and biological needs, that scents could communicate intent and emotions and needs and how all these things coming together created a boundless web of interactions and meaning.

It cleared up a lot for him. Helped him understand things that hadn’t made sense in the past, connect the dots from all the small incidents that had only left him confused. In the buried vestiges of his childhood memories, still left cracked and not quite all there, Phainon could recall where all these ‘dynamics’ existed, what he could remember observing, how it all now fit with what his textbooks explained.

Phainon learned how to regulate his scent, how pheromones work within his body. From what the other Heirs mentioned about him in passing, he realizes his innate scent profile was very different from what he had grown up with – Castorice spoke about dewy grasses, Aglaea mentioned something close to sunlight, Hyacine told him he reminded her of old prints and spilt ink.

That was his true scent? So deceptively *serene*? No iron, no ash?

Phainon becomes a beloved figure among the locals. The omegas would smile at him with gratitude, their eyes no longer widening with fear. The betas would gaze at him with relief whenever he drove away any aggressive alphas attempting to flaunt their territories. The alphas would stare at him with wary eyes – his demeanor shaped into something palatable enough that it did not set off their innate aggression, but firm enough to know he was not an alpha they could triumph over. But beneath all of that was their underlying respect.

In every manner, Phainon now held the countenance of a ‘perfect’ alpha, the reliable ‘Deliverer’. Strong and healthy, handsome and coveted and so, so in control of himself. No

one would look at him and ever imagine he used to be a wild animal years before, left only to the devices of raw instinct.

Phainon also knew otherwise.

Even after learning about ruts and heats and the kind of environment and companionship needed to go through them all – he understood it was still different for *him*.

That what he had been going through in all those years of travel – when he resorted to mindless slaughter and self-injury – had been his ruts. And nothing had really changed for him in that prospect.

It was when Phainon succumbed to his ruts that his perfectly prepared status as the 'Deliverer' cracked, cracked like the mirror he would stand before and see the distorted reflection of the figure cloaked in black again, the monster that never left his nightmares.

From what he was told – alphas in rut craved the company of an omegas, were driven by the uncontrollable want to have them in their den, to lick and devour and mate them until satiation, to fill them up with pups and build a nest for them to curl up in, basking in the warmth of their alpha's security. It was this instinct that often spiralled out of control in alphas – unmated alphas often posed a danger to society, especially if left unsupervised and with access to move outside, leading to several incidents of unwilling omegas targeted by their frenzy.

But it didn't work like that for Phainon. He couldn't explicitly conclude he *didn't* want an omega to give him company in those times – perhaps deep within, he did. But his ruts were still like the past – steeped in bloodlust. He still craved blood, craved to see the arc of his sword before it cut whatever it struck into two. Still craved his nails digging into his flesh.

Was *that* what he was supposed to let an omega witness? Let them be left to the mercy of whatever he became?

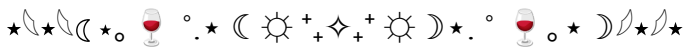
No – ruts were always a violent, furious, bloody affair to Phainon and nothing else. Each one leaving him burning and ashamed, leaving his memories in shambles, his body aching and wracked with fear.

The mere thought of letting someone witness that, handle that, was enough to make his stomach turn. He wasn't going to let that happen – let anyone be exposed to him in those

times. The quiet longing for relief and company remained, but the terror outweighed everything.

If it wasn't someone who could coexist with that bloodlust, who could understand that thirst for violence, then Phainon would keep that can of worms sealed, bolted and buried forever.

So, the ruts are still agony. They descend like wildfires, burning him from inside out. And Phainon deals with them in the only way he knew how, the only way he would allow himself and he gives in to the rage and brutality, as always. He takes on missions clearing out enemy frontlines whenever he feels a rut coming. Missions far, far away from the city, where no one would see what he would become.



“Is there something wrong with me?” Phainon asks his professor one day, hanging back after class.

Anaxa keeps pouring over his books without looking up.

“That is like asking ‘*why do bad things happen in the world*’, Phainon.”

“Pardon?”

“You need to be specific, instead of asking questions I could pen an entire book about for an answer.”

“…What is wrong with me as an alpha?”

Anaxa blinks, pausing mid-turn of a page and looks up. Phainon feels uncomfortable under his gaze – while he had learnt to decipher scents from all kinds of people, the professor was…a unique case.

Neither an alpha nor an omega. Phainon had initially suspected him to be an odd beta, but even betas had a neutral scent of their own.

For Anaxa, there was *nothing*. He was a madman who had alchemically experimented with and altered his own pheromones until he fell in neither of the three categories.

"He gave some asinine explanation about wanting to be truly neutral, to be able to observe all three with not even a hint of self-bias, or external sway." Aglaea had answered in a clipped tone when Phainon had asked.

"What was he…before?"

"Does it matter? All that he was means nothing to anyone." He catches a near-scowl on her face – a rarity to ever observe on the demigod's face.

"As an alpha." Anaxa repeats slowly.

"Yes."

"The fact that you *are* one is a '*wrong*' in itself, if you think about it, isn't it?"

Phainon stares back at him placidly. This was probably going to become a philosophical deep-dive into how the very idea of 'secondary genders' was a flawed concept, that there was something innately *wrong* with the human nature and Anaxa was the lone being striving for perfection-

"Is it about your messy ruts?" Anaxa looks back down towards his readings.

"…How-"

"And don't ask me how I know of it – no, Aglaea did not say anything to me. I could just tell. I am smarter than you."

"So why am I a defective alpha?"

"A *defective* alpha!" Anaxa exclaims, "Isn't the thirst for blood and domination *innate* to you all?"

"That's not how it is for other-"

"It *is*. Just because they have found ways to get around with it does not mean they do not have the lust for violence within them. Why do you think humans boast of themselves as

‘civilized’; it is because they suppress their baser instincts through nurture and punishment, through norms and rewards.”

“…”

“*Every* alpha has these instincts, Phainon – it is all but a matter of distracting themselves from part of said instincts by pandering to the rest. Do you believe those alphas lounging around in the arms of their mates are so drastically different from you? They sink their teeth into their mates and lick up their blood. They snag their bodies with the size of their knot, leaving them unable to escape. They command with a calculated maneuver of scents and pheromones. It always was never quite so different from the savagery you witness in the wilds – its intensity is just made *palatable* to the masses, that is all. *You* just did not get to be conditioned like that.”

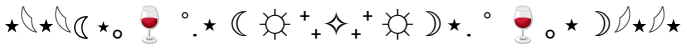
“But other alphas are also capable of love. Of protecting their mates – of *wanting* to do it.”

Anaxa looks up, face unreadable as always but with something weirdly piercing in his eyes.

“And what makes you think you are *incapable* of love, Phainon? Incapable of receiving it? Is it not the fear gripping your own heart that tells you so? You pushed the answer down your own throat without even attempting the question.”

His conversation with Anaxa did not really answer anything. Or perhaps, there *was* merit to it – no, Phainon *knew* there was truth in his words, that he was pointing him towards an answer Phainon was too afraid to look at.

~~The ruts are still agony. And Phainon writhes and kills through each, only this time, he longs for something far, far different from it all, even more than ever.~~



When Aglaea asks him to ‘deal with’ the Kremnoan detachment that was shaping up to be a thorn in the side of the Flame Chasers, Phainon accepts without question. Being a warrior matched by no one in Okhema left him quite wanting for a rival. And he had heard quite a number of tales about them and their monstrous prowess in battle, not a single one without their dramatizations.

The mighty army of Kremnos currently traversing across Amphoreus after abandoning their fallen nation, was quite a popular topic occupying marketplace gossip and whispers in the baths.

And their leader Mydeimos, the warrior prince drenched in bloodshed and patricide, was the crown jewel of all that gossip.

An alpha, shaped in blood and ruin.

Phainon was very interested to meet him.

When Phainon first sees Mydei, he was sitting a considerable distance away, with a cup of what he understood was blood, in his hand. Golden hair tinted with red flies with the breeze, forming the likeness of a lion’s mane, his amber eyes casting a sharp, yet disinterested gaze down upon him - so sharply visible even from that distance. It was a wonder really, how he sprawled with the dominance of a man yet to be conquered, maintaining his regal air and making the pile of debris he sat upon look like a throne.

Phainon swallowed. Mydei was far away, with hundreds of his men stationed between the prince and hero. And yet he picks up a scent – a scent too distinct, a scent that completely overwhelmed the rest. A scent of blood and iron, with a sweet undernote of fruit and something warmer, that Phainon couldn’t put a finger on. It could have been from anyone there, but he *knew* it was him.

An alpha that smelled like blood yet also something deceptively serene.

Phainon didn’t regret accepting Aglaea’s commission.

He doesn’t get to fight Mydei immediately. It is his troops that he battles against, first, while Mydei watches – it created the image of a sheltered prince, distant and detached and too indifferent to personally deal with the pest that had wandered into his territory. But deep down, Phainon knew he could change that.

Just dealing with the first few opponents alone sends the message across. Mydei raised an arm, a glint in his eyes and the fight immediately stops, his soldiers wordlessly stepping aside.

Phainon stands, quietly triumphant that he had established himself, while Mydei leapt from his ‘throne’, slowly approaching him like a lion finally stepping out to hunt.

It was strange. His scent should have grated on Phainon’s nerves – especially from an alpha like Mydei, who wasn’t even trying to conceal his imposition on the rest – an alpha handcrafted to either piss off the rest or completely subdue them with his presence. It should have angered Phainon even *more*, actually.

But he feels hardly anything. He could pick up his scent more clearly – rust and pomegranates and wood-fired ovens, could tell it had the obvious markings of an alpha…but it doesn’t affect him.

And in the ten days that Phainon spends battling this new rival of his – blow for blow, with no wins and no concessions, he realizes something. Blanketed by their scents sharpened by the haze of raw aggression, Phainon is almost *horrified* to learn that he was *drawn* to Mydei’s scent.

Was it because Mydei was inciting that high of bloodlust in him? What else could an alpha of his bearings incite in a fellow alpha like Phainon? It couldn’t be anything else; it only cemented the fact that Phainon was truly not meant for anything gentler than that-

So why *didn’t* he feel like ripping Mydei’s throat out? Why didn’t he imagine running his sword through him, biting away at him until the prince was completely conquered?

It didn’t make sense.

Nothing made sense. The reasoning that Phainon had crafted about himself, explaining why he was the way he was, it all started to crack, gradually revealing that very young man left alone in the harsh lands, confused and bereaved and so deeply afraid.

In every sense, Phainon should have avoided Mydei. His scent allured him, yes, but it surely did not mean anything good. Not when Mydei was what he was and all that two alphas could share was a race for conquest and clashes of bloodied pride.

But with the prince joining the Chrysos Heirs, it was difficult to stay away from him. Or that was what Phainon liked to tell himself.

But deep down, he knew it was something else – something driven by fascination. Curiosity. Longing.

Without realizing it, Phainon goads. Nudges at his composure. He challenges and he competes. And as was innate to an alpha's nature, Mydei indulges him, naturally and with unshakeable calm, even his rebukes laced with restraint.

What was it, really? Was Phainon associating the subtle scent of fruit with the sweetness of an omega? Was it the scent of iron that hung around Mydei, so similar to what he had himself grown with, yet so *unlike* his experience with how Mydei *wielded* it – composed and prevailing, not wild but a warning?

Perhaps to understand this is what makes Phainon seek out Mydei more, jumping into their little impromptu contests and spars, breathing in as much of him as he could. It was nothing more than that – nothing more than understanding the mystery behind why Mydei was affecting him the way he did.

Because that's all that it could ever be. They could never be anything more than two allies, two rivals.

Despite the unresolved mess of questions about himself that weighed him down, Phainon does notice something about Mydei as well as the months go by.

Mydei wasn't affected by his pheromones either, not in the manner a rival alpha should be. All the hostility, the tension that sparks between them is too reasonable to be the product of unregulated pheromones. If Mydei got irritated by Phainon, it was because of some shit Phainon did, like cracking a bad joke about Mydei's hair, not because he breathed around him wrong and Mydei wanted to bash his head in just for the heck of it.

Maybe that's just how Mydei *was* – frightfully in control of himself. But still, Phainon catches on to some things.

The way Mydei would lean into him – very, *very* slightly whenever they walked together or stood close.

The way his gaze would linger on his throat after a taxing mission – a little too long to be innocent.

The way Mydei seemed to have no problem with his touch, gruffly allowing him to throw his arm around his shoulders, even if Phainon made a show of doing it to pester him.

It has him toy around with fantasies of his own, those soft, persistent longings that he had buried years before that Mydei seemed just perfect for. Fantasies of companionship, of comfort, of tender feelings that doused the burn that would consume Phainon every month, gentle hands that did not flinch away. Fantasies that felt cathartic yet baffling at the same time. *Fantasies*, because they made no sense – because Phainon couldn't even think of such things with an omega – an alpha like Mydei would be the last person to be a suitable mate for him.

There was no world where two alphas being mated ever ended well.

And then, Phainon wakes up from a rut in his room, panting and in pain, and staggers towards a mirror. It is not the cloaked figure from his nightmares that greets him – it is his own tired, flushed self.

With Mydei's cloak wrapped around his shoulders, the metallic hint of blood and warmth of woodfires and fruit still lingering, nearly buried by his own scent.

Phainon was truly doomed.

He manages to sneak inside Mydei's quarters to stuff the garment inside his cupboard after washing. He nearly gets caught by one of his men stationed nearby while leaving.

Phainon still couldn't believe he *did that*.

Never again. He couldn't slip like that again. Phainon really did not want to think about the discussions that would explode in Okhema if it was discovered that their beloved Deliverer was spotted stealing a fellow *alpha's* clothes for his rut.

And most of all, catching sight of Mydei after his rut, having him treat him as the Deliverer he knew, the rival he trusted to watch his back – it wracks Phainon with the kind of guilt he couldn't bear.

He couldn't do that to Mydei. Think about him like that while sullying his belongings with his stench. And Phainon was sure Mydei had a mate of his own – which omega would be able to resist a being like him?

And yet, the collection of Mydei's items in his room only grows with each rut. Each wrecks him with more guilt yet each also has him become bolder, wanting more.

Anaxa's words echo in his mind and Phainon tries his best to shut it out, even when he knew what was happening. That it was Mydei he wanted.

The Mydei who would paint a picture of competitive arrogance whenever he won a bout against him, but unable to fully hide the concern in his deadpan eyes as he would watch Phainon stand to his feet.

The Mydei whose meals would always taste atrocious when he was mad at him, but strangely delicious whenever Phainon returned after his absences, silently reeling and recovering from his rut but unable to tell anyone.

The Mydei who sat beside him on a rooftop one evening, offering him a glass of chilled pomegranate juice while Phainon spoke. Of his childhood, of his village – not in details, not with names, not with the tragedies, but just his dreams, of his carefree days, the losses unsaid but understood.

The Mydei who paired it all with tales of his own, of a childhood spent in the ocean bed, being subjected to unending slaughter and death until he grew strong enough to inflict it upon

his foes with his own hands.

The Mydei who really did start off so similar to him but became so *different*. So much *better*.

And it all culminates with Phainon breaking into Mydei's room in his latest rut and burrowing himself into his bed, still freshly imbued with his scent, while the latter was away.

It wasn't enough that Phainon had literally *broken into another alpha's space* while in rut, but said alpha had also *discovered* him an hour later.

"…Ph-"

"*GET OUT!*"

And he also had the audacity to yell at him to get out. Out of his own room.

Phainon had fucked up. Royally, *royally fucked up*.

With all the weak protests he throws out, Phainon still doesn't understand why Mydei hadn't *done* anything. He had pretty much violated every code of etiquette by being in an alpha's room alone – Mydei was well within his rights to *kill* him.

But instead, Phainon finds himself scooped up in the prince's arms and tucked into his fucking bed.

He finds Mydei *offering himself as a mate*.

At one point, Phainon had been sure that his ruts had acquired a new symptom – transforming his fantasies into incredibly detailed hallucinations which never happened and he would wake up from them feeling incredibly stupid.

But when Phainon leans in to bury his face into Mydei's chest, breathing him in, his denial begins to slip from his grasp, forcing him to give in little by little. Even if it was all a hallucination…he could have this, couldn't he? Let himself savour the one thing he had denied himself for *so long*.

And with Mydei's patient instruction, Phainon gets to try so many of the little things he could never do alone. It was utterly *ridiculous* to make a nest for another alpha but Mydei only scoffs and lets him pick him up and settle him into it, even when Phainon, in what remained of his rational mind, knew most alphas would see it as indignity.

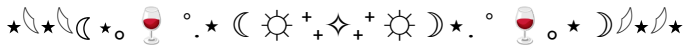
Amongst all the random thoughts floating in his dazed mind, Phainon wonders how Mydei dealt with his own ruts. Surely, he already had an omega partner of his own – this man never appeared as *ruined* as Phainon did whenever he returned from his monthly absences.

"I am simply more capable of enduring pain and suffering than you are."

Maybe that's what it was – just Mydei toughing it out. It was difficult to imagine a man like him to…*not* have a partner. He couldn't imagine Mydei not receiving a thousand offers of courtship every day.

"……have you return the favour…"

But Mydei had asked him. Asked *Phainon* to be his mate when his turn came.



"So what made you break into my room this time?"

"I…it wasn't the plan. I just wanted to borrow some stuff from here and go back."

This time, the rut had crashed upon him without warning and Phainon had understood almost immediately that he hadn't readied his room beforehand with Mydei's things as he usually did.

"Some stuff – wait, *you have broken in here before*?"

"Just to borrow things."

"Borrow – *YOU HAVE BEEN STEALING MY BELONGINGS?!*"

"It can't be considered stealing if I *returned* them afterwards, right?" Phainon glares up at the fuming prince, "I washed them too."

"…"

Phainon slumps back into the pillow.

"…It just made them *better*. I didn't understand why – and I was planning to leave your place after I got some of your clothes but the rut was already there and…and it smelled so *good*."

"…"

Mydei lets out a sigh, his features softening before he buries his face into his hair.

"And it was so much – I just wanted it to stop hurting and just being here took that pain away a bit and the next thing I knew, I was in your bed."

"Ask, next time." Mydei speaks into his hair, his fingers slowly curling against his scalp, "I am territorial about my belongings, as *all* alphas are… but I wouldn't have said no to you."

"I know." Phainon whispers, "I know that now."

The worst of the rut hits him like a hazy storm, as it always did, but Phainon was afraid now for a different reason. He wasn't out there facing enemies anymore; he couldn't just let himself go and succumb to the violence.

Not when Mydei was right there.

Even if Phainon knew if there was anyone who could subdue him, it was him.

And he tries, tries, tries to stay afloat, until he couldn't, until he barely registers lunging at Mydei, pleading with his own self to stop-

And Mydei holds him down, utterly unflinching at his aggression, matching his rage with his unyielding strength, staring him down with that steady glare.

"Deliverer."

And his voice is so soft.

"I can handle you."

Phainon sobs and Mydei kisses him.

"I don't – I don't know what else-" he writhes and his hips roll up against Mydei who lets out a gasp – the friction making both of them very aware of their mutual state of arousal that they had been trying to ignore all the while.

To Phainon's hazy surprise, Mydei doesn't freeze – he grinds his hips *down* instead, hard and deliberate and he feels his toes curl from the pleasure that simple gesture hands to him.

“Because you didn’t *allow* yourself anything else.”

Mydei grinds down again and Phainon clutches at him-

“Mydei – told you I can’t mate-”

“I *know*-”

Phainon yelps as Mydei shifts over him, strong hands grabbing his waist before he falls to the side, pulling him to settle on top of him.

“But Deliverer – you need to find something other than bloodshed to lose yourself in.” Mydei grabs his face and pulls him into a kiss, making Phainon moan into his mouth with an upward thrust, “Let yourself want – chase it all you want. You don’t have to claim anything now – take what you can handle.”

Phainon squeezes his eyes shut; the guilt burns him from within as he grinds down on Mydei and the sheer pleasure and *want* that grips him has him repeating it. Mydei arches under him, his throat exposed, glistening and tempting to bite and Phainon presses open kisses along its length, tasting the sweat, smelling the sweet hint of blood.

“And if you start to forget yourself-” Mydei pants while Phainon keep rutting against him, “I’ll stop you. I won’t let you cross the line and become something you regret.”

…

And Phainon slips.

Lets himself slip.

The haze it puts him in still is more lucid compared to all the previous ones. Desire bleeding into places where rage once ruled, heat in his veins no longer burning for blood. The pain of nails digging into his skin is replaced by the pleasure of Mydei’s arousal pressing against his, their gasps and groans drowning out the static that used to fill his ears.

His senses return to him occasionally, and Phainon spends these short periods of clarity cuddling with Mydei in silence, before the next wave hit and he resumed humping against his thigh.

“What are you thinking about?” Mydei murmurs against his hair, during one of these lulls.

Phainon blinks wearily. His body was already overloaded from his rut, his clothes felt sticky from the spent smeared into them, and the sheer heat of Mydei’s body wasn’t really helping. He feels a small kiss against his head and finds himself melting.

Yes, it *really* wasn’t helping.

“…You asked me to return the favour later.”

“Are you having second thoughts about agreeing, Deliverer?”

“No – that’s not it.”

Phainon’s hair slightly ruffles as Mydei lets out a sigh.

“I assumed you would understand without having me spell it out – I’m not genuinely expecting anything back from you-”

“I didn’t say no.” Phainon gives a light nip at his neck to shut him up, “I don’t have any regrets either – it’s just…I said yes so easily. Being an alpha and…”

“…”

Phainon gives a small lick against Mydei’s throat, tasting the salt of it and feels him slightly shudder.

He wasn’t supposed to be this way. Offer himself up so easily.

Mydei’s hand presses flat against his back, rubbing a slow circle against it and Phainon stills at the low vibration that he feels against his chest and nuzzles against him even more.

He wasn't supposed to enjoying this. Falling so easily in the arms of another like this. Melting to the sound of Mydei's crooning like this. Eating up his moans like he did.

"I wasn't raised to be a proper one and now I don't know – every time I feel like I understand why it is this way…it just ends up being different and making no sense."

"I am not too different now, am I? Which alpha in my position would tolerate this in the slightest?"

"That's why I told you – you don't-"

"I'm not putting up with it." Mydei brushes his lips against his forehead, "It's…not bad. I can't defy every little aspect of my biological instincts, but I was not expecting a little shit like you would aggravate it so *little*."

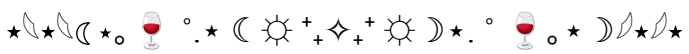
"Weren't you slamming me against the floor just a few hours ago?"

"You were trying to *kill* me, you HKS! You should be glad it was just you – anyone else and I would have cracked their skull open."

Phainon mulls over that in silence for a while.

"So…I'm special to you."

"If you decide to keep bringing it up like a pest, I will toss you out of the window, Deliverer."



Mydei pries himself away from Phainon to get to the kitchen only to get dragged back again.

"HKS!" he snaps while Phainon crawls over him, staring him down with wide eyes and slightly pouted lips, looking like a puppy whose toy was being snatched, "We need to eat and considering our states, we'll be emptying an entire grocery store!"

Their clothes were scattered around the room, though Phainon had insisted upon swaddling his own garments around Mydei's shoulders.

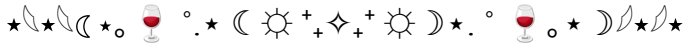
At least their underwears were still on.

"I'll cook."

"You little – I'm conceding to a *lot* of things for you here, considering you're in rut, but letting you *cook* is not going to be one of them."

Phainon gives him a beseeching glare. Mydei doesn't budge. As important as it was to make him believe he was 'taking care of his mate', ending up with food poisoning would only establish the opposite once this fool came out of it.

But as a small allowance, Mydei lets Phainon feed him, watching him with an amused smile as the Heir practically lights up at the chance.



"Lord Phainon! Norma only wants *you* to feed her the mud!"

"Coming!" Phainon calls out, giving the ornate spoon a last look before handing it back to Theodoros with a smile, and jogging over to the waiting dromas.

As he tries to shape a palmful of red soil into a clump, he catches sight of Mydei in his periphery and his breath involuntarily hitches.

It had been a few days since his rut had ended.

Things had gone back to normal, as they always did.

Phainon was out in the golden streets again, back as the perfect Deliverer he was known as. As if nothing had happened.

The warmth of Mydei's body still lingered on him.

Mydei was saying something to Kokopo the Third, probably cooing to it with the same gentle voice that he had praised Phainon with-

Their gazes meet. Phainon feels his throat tighten, heat prickling at his neck. A long, wet appendage swipes at his cheek and he flinches, turning around to face Norma, who was staring at him with beady eyes, licking at his cheek again.

"Yeah – yeah, big guy. I have your snack right here."

Phainon tries to focus on feeding the dromas for the next while until he hears footsteps approach, the scent of pomegranates and iron filling his nose as Mydei rests his chin on his shoulder.

"You really do have a habit of feeding with your hands, don't you Deliverer?"

Phainon clears his throat and continues feeding the soil to Norma while Mydei pets its snout, trying not to be too conscious of the way his scent that gradually enveloped them both, the way his heat seeped through the thick material of his coat to let itself be felt

"I wonder when you shall return the favour." Mydei speaks into his ear, voice low and amused, leaving Phainon too flushed and frozen to react when he presses a kiss against his neck, right over his scent gland before walking away.

When Phainon finally turns around, Mydei was already a good distance away, leaving him with nothing but a red face and something fragile and softer curling up inside his chest. Something he would no longer have to deny.

End Notes

ok so i finally decided to open my inbox to reply to the comments＼(｡＞ᴗ＜)／＼(｡＞ᴗ＜)／ I really do see them you all i genuinely love and appreciate them i just royally procrastinate with replies.

I yap about them in my twitter

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!